The collapse of the Chinese empire, and the disintegration of the country that followed in its wake, provided non-Chinese vassals in the outlying areas with an opportunity to reassert the autonomy or de facto independence several of them had enjoyed even under the emperors. The Mongol tribes, which, under rulers such as Ghengis Khan and Kublai Khan, had conquered much of Asia in the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries, had gradually been subdued by the Chinese emperors. Under the Qing Dynasty, the land of the Mongols was divided into a more directly controlled ‘inner’ section and an ‘outer’ part on the steppes and highlands north of the Gobi desert, which was self-governing and corresponds to the modern state of Mongolia.

As early as 29 December 1911, only two-and-a-half months after the outbreak of the republican revolution in China, Mongolia declared its independence. The Mongols practised the same kind of Buddhism as in Tibet, with a clergyman titled ‘Bogd Gegeen’, or ‘the Holy Enlightened One’, as the highest religious authority in the country. He now assumed the title of ‘Bogd Khan’, ‘Holy Ruler’, of the new theocratic Mongolian state. Although governed by supposedly peaceful Buddhist clerics, the Mongols felt they had to build up an army to defend their newly won independence. Shortly after the declaration of independence, they launched a military campaign to ‘liberate’ Inner Mongolia also from the Chinese.

The Mongols turned to Russia to buy weapons for their fledgling armed forces, but Tsar Nicholas II was not interested in supporting a war against the newly proclaimed Republic of China. Unknown to the Mongols, the Russians had in the same year, 1912, concluded a secret agreement with the Japanese, delineating their respective spheres of influence in China’s northern periphery. Southern Manchuria and Inner Mongolia came within Japan’s sphere, while Japan recognized Russia’s right to exert its influence over northern Manchuria and Outer Mongolia.[3]

Thus, no Russian weapons were ever sent to Mongolia, nor were the Russians prepared to annex any part of Mongolia despite the secret pact with Japan. But, on 3 November 1912 (21 October, according to the Russian calendar), Russia and Mongolia signed a treaty by which the Russians recognized Outer Mongolia’s autonomy within the then newly constituted Republic of China. The Mongolian version of the treaty, however, said ‘independence’, which was interpreted by the Mongols as